

GOLDEN TOUCH Abhinav Bindra after winning the gold medal in the Men's 10m Air Rifle at the Beijing Olympics, Aug. 11, 2008

AFP

ABHINAV BINDRA: FIRST SOLO OLYMPIC GOLD, 2008

The Golden Trendsetter

The calm of a yogi, the eye of a hunter. Abhinav Bindra needed that. For, he was about to shoot down demons of the collective Indian mind

BY RAHUL NORONHA

It's de rigueur these days for sportspeople to be a little exhibitionistic with their emotions—leaps of joy, chest-butting, flowing tears, or what in the animal world are called ritualised aggression and 'agonistic' displays. Sixteen years ago, a young man showed another way to be. A zen-like halo of quiet seemed to surround his bespectacled face, even as the Indians in the stands went wild. They had reason to. Abhinav Bindra had just happened. India's first individual Olympic gold. The *first*. In 2008, its 61st year as a free nation. Bindra, boyish at 26, bookish of manner, and half a foot shorter than the Finn he was tied with in the final, looked as if he had just stepped out of a library. But outside of him, he was setting off a storm. Far beyond this shooting range in suburban Beijing. Or the collective of Indian sport lovers. If instead of his .177 calibre Walther LG 300 rifle, he was aiming a flaming arrow at the heart of dormant ambitions among Indian athletes, you'd still say he hit dead centre. To count those who came in his wake, you don't only think shooters.